MOSCOW, RUSSIA

# State Tretyakov Gallery: Masterpieces

Portraits, invented beings and political allegories test the distance between a person and an emblem.



A girl at a table needs peaches, a knife and a light-filled room to make her particular setting clear. Kustodiev's enormous Bolshevik, by contrast, strides above buildings that cannot contain him. The difference is a question of scale and purpose, not simply of accurate and inaccurate bodies. One picture gives a sitter a lived setting; the other makes a body carry a political force.

Between these extremes, the selection includes portraits whose names are known, a woman whose identity remains unresolved, and figures drawn from history or legend. Landscapes complicate the comparison by making people small or dispensing with them. *Black Square* withdraws the recognisable scene altogether, while remaining a physical painted object.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

## Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context  Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/tretyakov-gallery

# The selection · 20

1. Girl with Peaches
   Valentin Serov · 1887
2. Black Square
   Kazimir Malevich · 1915
3. Seated Demon
   Mikhail Vrubel · 1890
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   Isaac Levitan · 1895
5. Bathing a Red Horse
   Kuzma Petrov-Vodkin · 1912
6. Ivan the Terrible and His Son Ivan
   Ilya Repin · 1883-1885
7. Portrait of an Unknown Woman
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8. The Vision of the Young Bartholomew
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10. Portrait of Modest Mussorgsky
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16. Country Road
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17. The Snow Maiden
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18. The Bolshevik
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19. The Philosophers Bulgakov and Florensky
    Mikhail Nesterov · 1917
20. Ivan Morozov
    Valentin Serov · 1910

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# Girl with Peaches

Valentin Serov

1887 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Valentin Serov. Girl with Peaches. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The peaches and knife keep the table available for ordinary use rather than making it a ceremonial portrait prop. Serov's light extends beyond the girl's shoulders, so the room continues around her settled yet loose pose. The image gives an impression of a moment within daily life. That effect is a pictorial achievement, not proof that the painting required only a moment to make.

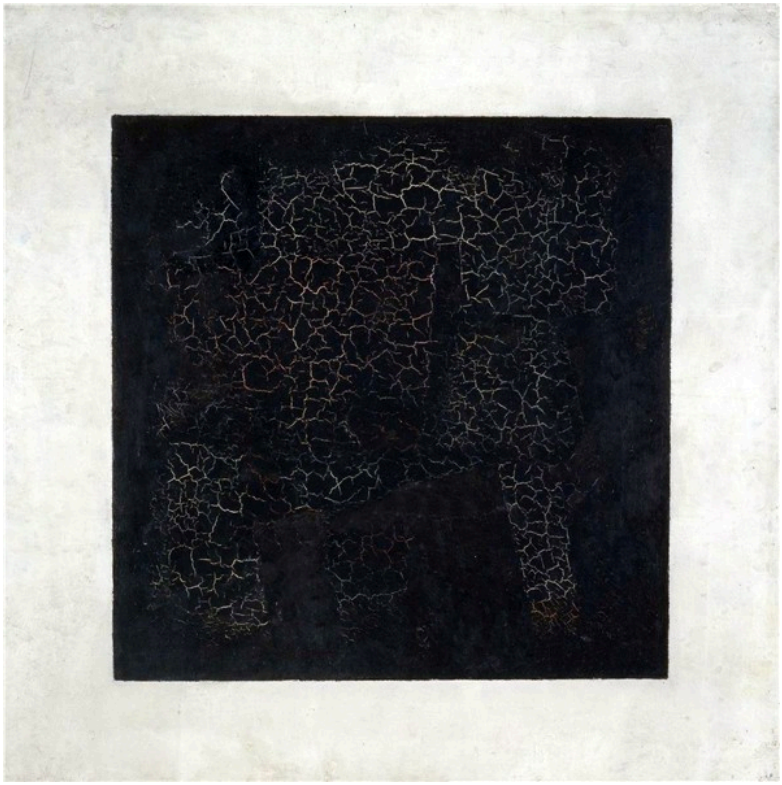
Object source · Open artwork

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# Black Square

Kazimir Malevich

1915 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Kazimir Malevich. Black Square. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

No depicted person or landscape provides an entry into the dark quadrilateral. Malevich makes its relationship with the pale field the painting's overt proposition. Yet the edges are not mechanically perfect, and the aged surface has cracks. An apparently absolute form exists here in material with a history. Recognising that fact does not require turning it back into a hidden illustrated scene.

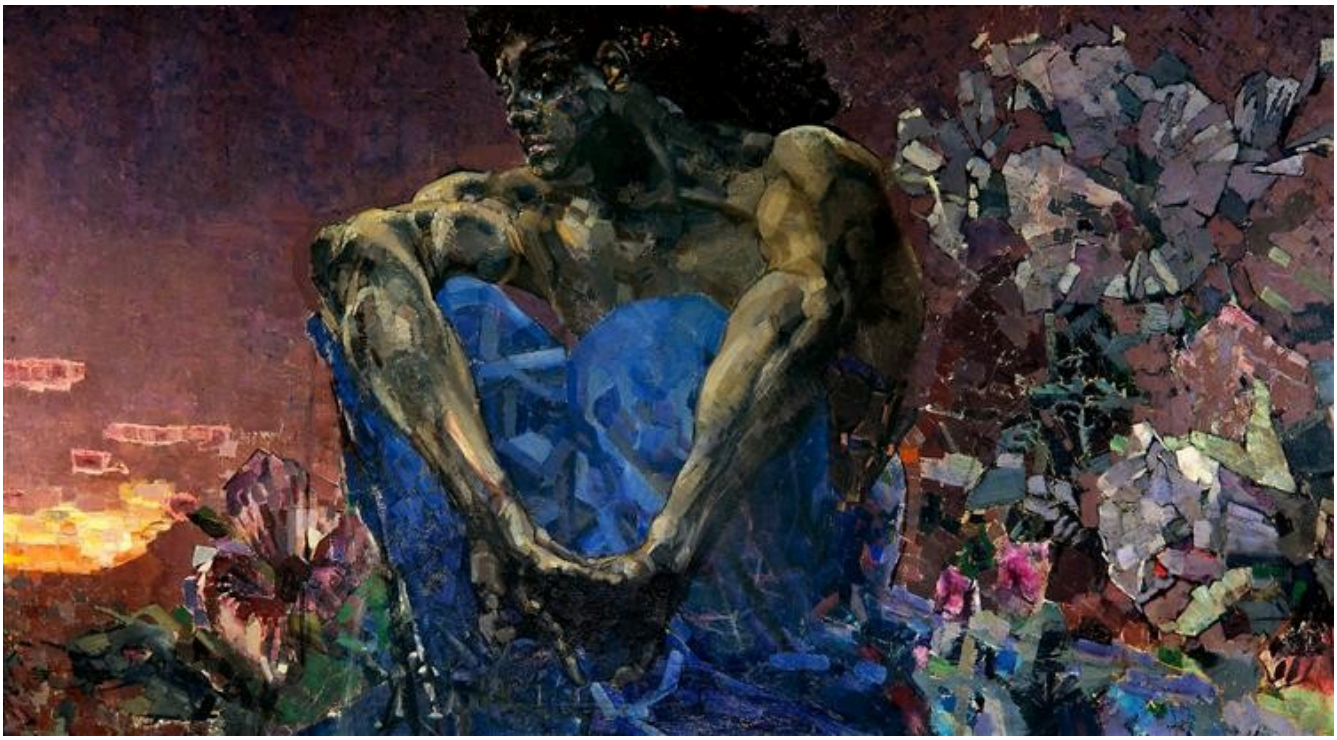
Object source · Open artwork

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# Seated Demon

Mikhail Vrubel

1890 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Mikhail Vrubel. Seated Demon. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The powerful body has little room to extend within the low format. Clasped hands and a hunched posture keep its strength contained, while angular, flower-like forms connect it to the surrounding surface. Vrubel gives an imagined being a conflict of scale: the figure seems capable of force, yet its present arrangement prevents that force from becoming uncomplicated action.

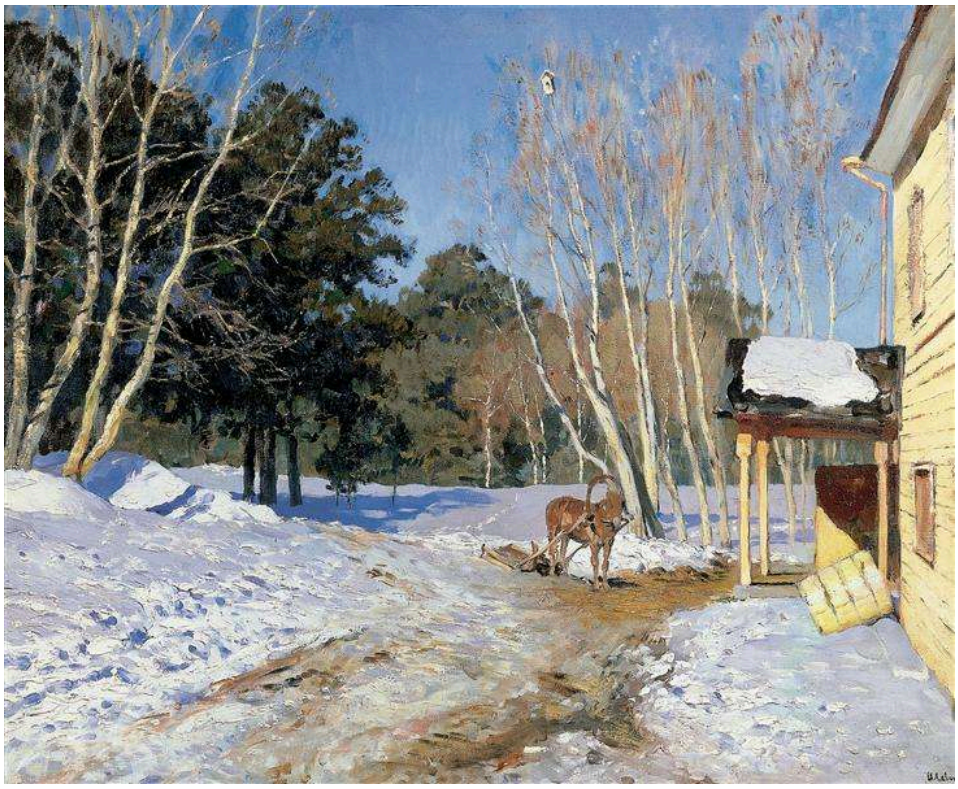
Object source · Open artwork

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# March

Isaac Levitan

1895 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Isaac Levitan. March. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Melting snow exposes a track that is neither fully winter ground nor fully cleared earth. Warm light on the wooden building contrasts with blue shadows among the trees. Levitan makes seasonal change visible as simultaneous conditions, not a clean replacement of one season by another. The waiting horse supplies an ordinary pause within that longer transformation.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Bathing a Red Horse

Kuzma Petrov-Vodkin

1912 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Kuzma Petrov-Vodkin. Bathing of a Red Horse. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The horse's broad red flank dominates figures and water that remain recognisable as a bathing scene. Petrov-Vodkin keeps bodily weight while departing from expected colour and ordinary scale. That combination lets the animal exceed a purely descriptive role without becoming unreadable. Its symbolic possibilities begin in the disproportion the picture makes visible, rather than in one compulsory explanation.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Ivan the Terrible and His Son Ivan

Ilya Repin

1883-1885 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Ilya Repin. Ivan the Terrible and His Son Ivan on November 16, 1581. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The older man's supporting hands cannot reverse the wound around which the bodies are joined. Repin stages the aftermath of violence, with patterned carpets and rich furnishings continuing around an embrace that has become desperate. The image is a historical reconstruction, not eyewitness evidence. Its strongest argument is made through the failure of a protective gesture to undo what preceded it.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Portrait of an Unknown Woman

Ivan Kramskoi

1883 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Ivan Kramskoi. Portrait of an Unknown Woman. Image credit: Ivan Kramskoi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The raised carriage seat positions the woman's direct look above the snowy street. Fashionable dark clothing contributes to a carefully presented public appearance. Kramskoi makes the encounter specific while leaving identity unresolved. The temptation to supply a biography from the costume or expression should be resisted: the picture gives a convincing presence, not enough evidence for a name or personal story.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 5893

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# The Vision of the Young Bartholomew

Mikhail Nesterov

1890 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Mikhail Nesterov. The Vision of the Young Bartholomew. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The boy and hooded monk meet at the edge of a broad, recognisable landscape. Inclined heads and small gestures give the sacred episode a close human scale. Nesterov does not remove the encounter from ordinary fields and woodland. The setting matters because it allows the extraordinary event to inhabit terrain that remains physically comprehensible.

Object source · Open artwork

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# After Prince Igor's Battle

Viktor Vasnetsov

1880 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Viktor Vasnetsov. After prince Igor's battle. Image credit: Viktor Vasnetsov. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The warriors can no longer act within the landscape that contains them. Birds, scattered weapons and shields give the open ground details through which the aftermath becomes readable. Vasnetsov shifts the literary-historical battle from combat to stillness. The absence of an active hero makes the bodies left behind, rather than a climactic individual deed, the substance of the scene.

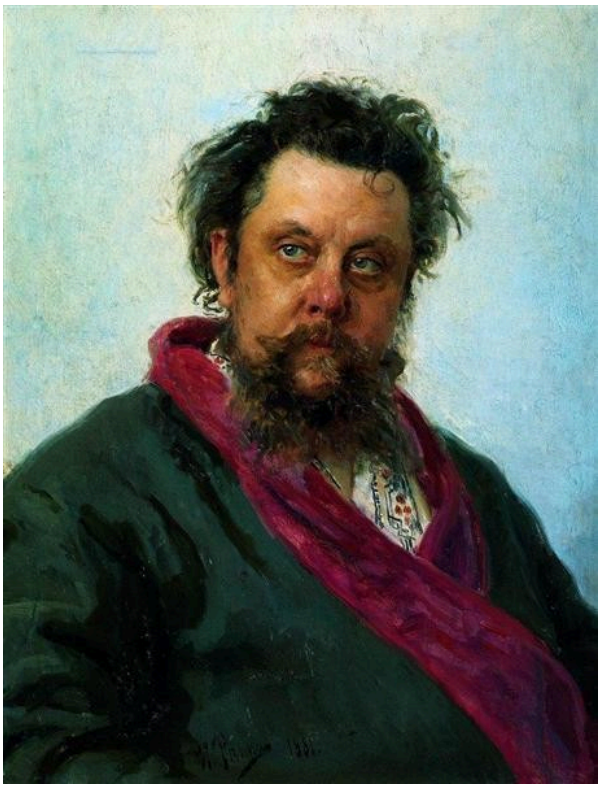
Object source · Open artwork

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# Portrait of Modest Mussorgsky

Ilya Repin

1881 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Ilya Repin. Portrait of the Composer Modest Musorgsky. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The loose dressing gown does not supply the formal public costume expected in a portrait of a distinguished composer. Repin keeps untidy hair and reddened features available to inspection. The likeness grants physical frailty the same sustained attention as recognition. It need not translate every sign of condition into a moral judgment or a diagnosis to remain exacting.

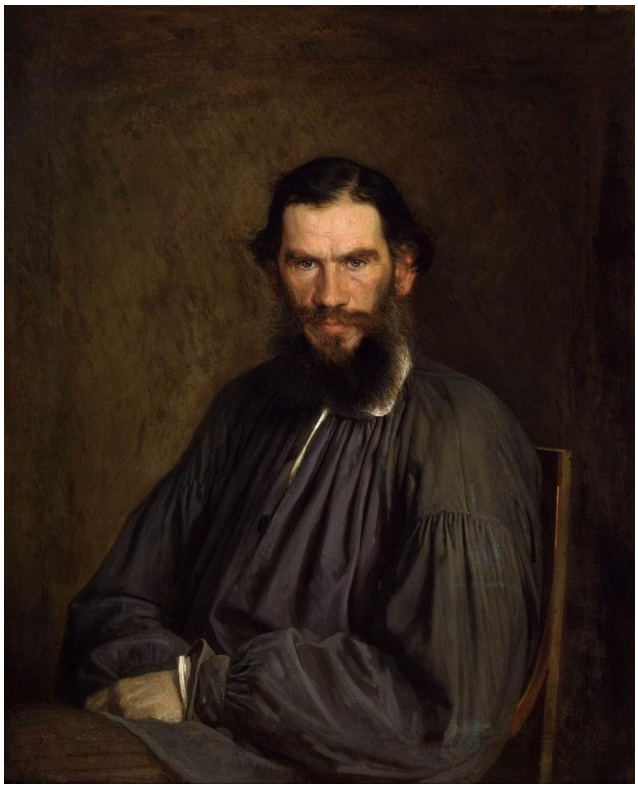
Object source · Open artwork

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# Portrait of Leo Tolstoy

Ivan Kramskoi

1873 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Ivan Kramskoi. Portrait of Leo Tolstoy. Image credit: Ivan Kramskoi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dark loose shirt and restrained ground offer few accessories through which to identify a celebrated writer. Kramskoi directs attention instead towards the gaze, beard and low-gathered hands. The portrait relies on the particular body's presence rather than a library or literary emblem. Simplicity is still a choice of presentation, not the absence of one.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 655

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# A Quiet Monastery

Isaac Levitan

1890 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Isaac Levitan. Quiet cloister. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The narrow bridge offers a route across reflective water towards the monastery buildings. Levitan makes the distant religious site reachable within the landscape instead of isolating it as an architectural icon. Trees and water separate the stages of approach. The quiet depends on those measured intervals, with a possible human passage remaining present even when no large figure directs it.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Evening Bells

Isaac Levitan

1892 · Oil on canvas · State Tretyakov Gallery



Isaac Levitan. Vesper chimes. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/isaac-levitan/vesper-chimes-1892 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The title introduces a sound the painting cannot literally produce. Broad water and remote monastery buildings supply the imagined distance across which it might travel. Levitan gives that suggestion a physical setting through reflection, boats and evening clouds. The visual account remains precise enough that the named sound adds an association rather than replacing the landscape's structure.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Overseas Guests

Nicholas Roerich

1901 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Nicholas Roerich. Overseas Guests. Image credit: Nicholas Roerich. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The red sails and repeated shields make the vessel a conspicuous pattern as well as a means of travel. Roerich constructs a distant historical world through strong colour and ornament. Boats and rocky shores preserve the setting, but the ship's surface demands attention in its own right. The result is an imagined past with a visibly designed appearance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: Ж-494

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# The Beekeeper

Ivan Kramskoi

1872 · Oil on canvas · State Tretyakov Gallery



Ivan Kramskoi. Beekeeper. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ivan-kramskoy/beekeeper-1872 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The staff, pale shirt and lowered head define an elderly man among plants and wooden hives. Kramskoi keeps the figure within the conditions of work rather than detaching him as a generalised emblem of the countryside. His slow posture contrasts with the dense growth. The surrounding ground has uses and occupations beyond serving as a background for age.

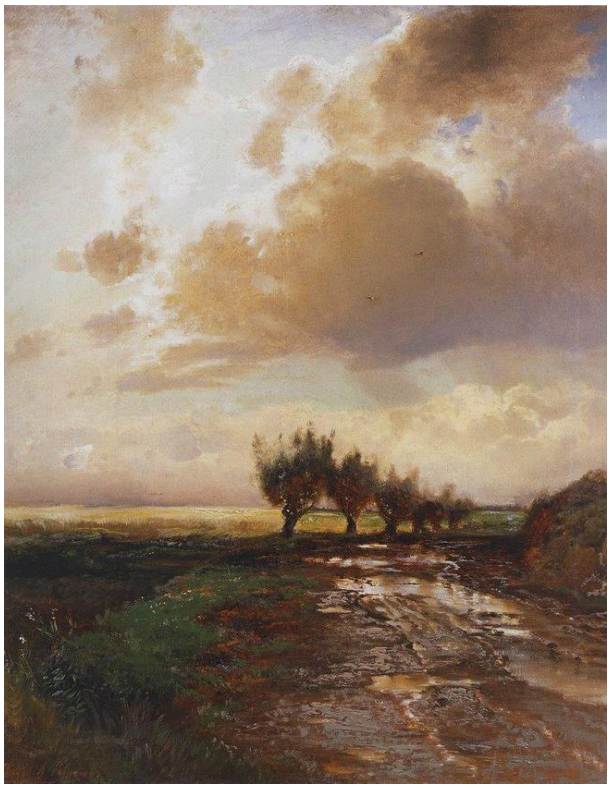
Object source · Open artwork

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# Country Road

Alexei Savrasov

1873 · Oil on canvas · State Tretyakov Gallery



Alexei Savrasov. Country road. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/aleksey-savrasov/country-road-1873 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Ruts and pools make the road an uneven way into the view. Savrasov retains the effects of weather on ground that might otherwise serve as a smooth perspective device. Broken clouds and changing light connect the near surface to the sky. The landscape becomes traversable in a bodily sense, including the difficulties of making that passage.

Object source · Open artwork

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# The Snow Maiden

Viktor Vasnetsov

1899 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Viktor Vasnetsov. Snow Maiden. Image credit: Viktor Vasnetsov. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The pale costume separates the girl from a forest that remains dark around her. Vasnetsov gives a legendary figure a particular place of exposure, between illuminated snow and enclosing trees. The contrast is enough to establish a precarious presence without retelling every part of the tale. The setting contributes to her condition rather than merely identifying a season.

Object source · Open artwork

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# The Bolshevik

Boris Kustodiev

1920 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Boris Kustodiev. The Bolshevik. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The banner carrier is too large for the streets and roofs beneath him. Kustodiev makes political force visible through this deliberate mismatch of scale. The crowded city becomes the ground over which an allegorical body strides. The painting offers a constructed image of revolutionary power; its emphatic figure should not be mistaken for an impartial summary of the events it invokes.

Object source · Open artwork

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# The Philosophers Bulgakov and Florensky

Mikhail Nesterov

1917 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Mikhail Nesterov. Portrait of the philosophers S.N. Bulgakov and P.A. Florensky. Image credit: Mikhail Nesterov. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Walking side by side supplies the paired portrait with an ordinary shared action. Pale and dark clothing distinguish the men before their separate looks and gestures are considered. Nesterov makes intellectual companionship visible without requiring an emblem of abstract thought. Togetherness remains compatible with different states of attention, held within the same path rather than the same expression.

Object source · Open artwork

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# Ivan Morozov

Valentin Serov

1910 · State Tretyakov Gallery



Valentin Serov. Ivan Morozov. Image credit: Unknown author Unknown author. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The sitter's sober clothing stands against pictures whose colours remain markedly more active. Serov gives a collector an identity partly through the art occupying his surroundings. Clasped hands anchor the near figure while the background records chosen visual company. A portrait can therefore describe taste through an arrangement of things without needing to illustrate every detail of a life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 10872

# Keep scale in view

Compare the ordinary-sized portrait sitter with the enlarged allegorical figure, then return to a landscape in which people barely appear. Scale changes what a body can stand for. The Tretyakov's works are distributed across venues and changing displays; check current location information before treating the selection as a visit plan.

# Further reading

## Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky’s book offers a contemporary argument for painting beyond literal representation. Read it beside Black Square as another position within early modern art, not as a statement of Malevich’s own programme or beliefs.

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Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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